

Building agents for real-world challenges

AI that doesn't just
provide answers—it
helps you take action.

PARTICIPANT FAQ

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Welcome! This page collects answers to the most common questions we've received from participants. It's a living document — we'll update it as new questions come in, so check back if you don't see your question covered.

If your question isn't here, post a new topic on the Discussions page at https://rapid-agent.devpost.com/forum_topics and we'll get back to you.

BILLING & GOOGLE CLOUD CREDITS

Q: How do billing and free credits work? Do I get free credits for partner services (Elastic, Arize, Fivetran, MongoDB, Dynatrace) too?

Google Cloud credits cover ONLY native Google Cloud services — Vertex AI, Gemini APIs, Cloud Run, Secret Manager, Agent Builder, etc. Each partner's credit, trial, or platform offering is

INDEPENDENT and accessed through that partner's dedicated section on the Resources tab (<https://rapid-agent.devpost.com/resources>).

To avoid unexpected charges, follow this sequence:

1. Claim your Google Cloud credits first. Redeem the hackathon credit code before deploying any infrastructure. Confirm the credits are visible in Google Cloud Console under Billing > Credits.
2. Access partner-specific resources separately. Activate the trials and developer-tier accounts for Elastic, Arize, Fivetran, MongoDB, and Dynatrace via the Resources tab.
3. Configure a budget alert. In Google Cloud Console, go to Billing > Budgets & alerts and set a hard budget limit of \$0 (or equal to your credit amount) with SMS/email notifications.
4. Clean up daily. Delete or pause Cloud Run services, Agent Builder instances, and vector database endpoints when you're not actively building.

Q: Are 100 Google Cloud credits actually enough?

In most cases yes — Vertex AI is billed incrementally and 100 credits typically covers millions of API tokens. To stretch them further, use the independent developer tiers and trials from our partners (MongoDB, Elastic, Arize, Fivetran, Dynatrace) — those don't draw down your Google Cloud credits.

Q: I'm getting a "Billing setup can't be completed" error when adding a debit card.

This is a known issue with certain debit cards. **IMPORTANT:** don't retry repeatedly — multiple failed attempts can trigger an automated security hold on your Google account.

Instead:

1. Go to the Google Cloud Billing Support page (<https://console.cloud.google.com/support>) — no admin role or active billing account needed.
2. Open the Support Contact Troubleshooter (<https://support.google.com/cloud/contactflow/billing>) and select "Issues with your form of payment."
3. Submit a case or open a live chat. Mention you're setting up billing to redeem hackathon credits. Google Cloud Billing support is free for all accounts, including trials and promotional credits.

Q: The Google Cloud billing page just keeps loading. What do I do?

Usually a browser cache, ad-blocker, or temporary console issue. Try these in order:

- Open an Incognito/Private window and try again.
- Disable ad-blockers (uBlock Origin, Privacy Badger, and Brave Shields commonly block billing scripts).
- Switch to Google Chrome if you're using another browser.

If it's still stuck, go directly to console.cloud.google.com/billing, or open the Support Contact Troubleshooter (<https://support.google.com/cloud/contactflow/billing>) for 24/7 live chat — free for all accounts.

Q: I can't activate Google Cloud billing because my international card / debit card isn't being accepted. What are my options?

Google Cloud's billing verification (including India's RBI e-mandate check) is a Google-side requirement that hackathon organizers cannot override or bypass — promotional credits require a valid billing profile to bind to. A few workarounds that have helped past participants:

1. **Virtual / forex cards from local fintechs.** For Indian participants: Niyo, HDFC ForexPlus, and Federal Bank issue prepaid cards designed for international services that often pass GCP's verification.
2. **Contact Google Cloud Billing Support directly** at <https://cloud.google.com/support/billing> — they can sometimes manually clear verification holds.
3. **Build with ADK in a local Python environment.** If you have access to Gemini APIs (e.g., via AI Studio or other channels) but can't activate full Google Cloud billing, a code-first ADK build with free-tier hosting (Streamlit Cloud, Render) is fully acceptable for submission — see the architecture question above.

Q: My Google Cloud credit coupon isn't redeeming — billing accounts show as inactive/ineligible. What do I do?

This is a Google Cloud billing account issue that hackathon organizers cannot resolve directly. Contact Google Cloud Billing Support at <https://cloud.google.com/support/billing> — they can investigate and clear the flag. In the meantime, signing up for a standard Google Cloud free trial at <https://cloud.google.com/free> can prevent lost development time while your account is being resolved.

 ELIGIBILITY & ACCESS

Q: Do I need a Gemini Enterprise account to participate?

No. Anyone can build for this hackathon using a standard Google Cloud project with billing enabled and the promotional credits provided for the event.

Quick context on the naming: Vertex AI features have been integrated into the broader "Gemini Enterprise Agent Platform" branding. The developer tools you'll use — Google Cloud Agent Builder (formerly Vertex AI Search and Conversation), Vertex AI, Gemini APIs — are unchanged and accessible to everyone. "Gemini Enterprise" as a brand family includes Workspace productivity apps, but you don't need any of that to build agents.

 AGENT ARCHITECTURE & TOOLS

Q: What do I need to build for my submission?

Your submission is a functional AI agent that:

1. Is **powered by Gemini** (Google's models)
2. Is **built within the Google Cloud Agent Builder ecosystem** — either via the visual Studio console OR the code-first ADK / Agent Runtime / Cloud Run path (both are valid)
3. **Integrates at least one participating partner's MCP server** — MongoDB, Elastic, GitLab, Arize, Fivetran, or Dynatrace
4. Has a **hosted Project URL** judges can access (a no-login sandbox demo with sample data is fine) and a **3-minute demo video**

See the [full rules](#) and the architecture/tools questions below for details.

Q: What agent architecture is required? Can I use the Agent Development Kit (ADK), LangChain, LangGraph, or LlamaIndex?

Your submission must be built within the Google Cloud Agent Builder ecosystem, which includes two equivalent paths:

- **Visual path:** the Google Cloud Agent Builder UI console (low-code, rapid prototyping)
- **Code-first path:** the Agent Development Kit (ADK) — programmatically scaffold, configure, and orchestrate your agent with the ADK SDK / CLI and deploy to the managed runtime (Cloud Run, Agent Runtime, etc.)

Both paths are fully supported — pick whichever fits your style. The core requirements stay the same either way:

- Powered by **Gemini**
- Built within the **Google Cloud Agent Builder** ecosystem (visual console OR ADK / Agent Runtime / Cloud Run — all valid)
- Integrates at least one **participating partner's MCP server** (MongoDB, Elastic, GitLab, Arize, Fivetran, or Dynatrace)

What's restricted: third-party runtime frameworks or orchestrators that directly compete with Google Cloud's agent ecosystem. Frameworks like LangChain, LangGraph, and LlamaIndex shouldn't be your primary orchestrator — Agent Builder / ADK should be.

Note for the Arize track: Arize's tracing integration requires a code-owned runtime (ADK, Agent Runtime, or Cloud Run). Building for the Arize track with the code-first ADK path satisfies both Arize's tracing requirement and the Agent Builder requirement.

Q: I can't find "Google Cloud Agent Builder" in the GCP Console — I only see "Agent Platform → Studio." Are these the same thing?

Yes, those are the same product. Google is mid-transition on the branding: the developer documentation still says "Google Cloud Agent Builder," but the GCP Console UI now shows it under **Agent Platform → Studio** (part of the broader Gemini Enterprise Agent Platform). There's no disruption to the underlying service — Studio is the Agent Builder interface.

Q: Can I use AI-assisted coding tools (Claude, Cursor, GitHub Copilot, AntiGravity) during development?

Per Section 7B of the official rules, **only Google Cloud AI tools (Gemini models, Google Cloud Agent Builder) and your chosen track partner's built-in AI features are permitted.** All other AI tools are not permitted — and this applies both to AI services integrated into your final project AND to AI tools used in your development workflow.

- **Not permitted:** Claude, Cursor, GitHub Copilot, and other competing AI coding assistants.
- **Permitted:** Google's AntiGravity suite is fully compliant.

To avoid any disqualification risk during code review, make sure your repository and development environment are free of competitor AI dependencies.

Q: Can I use Google Antigravity instead of Google Cloud Agent Builder?

Antigravity is a development tool — the successor to Gemini CLI — not a replacement for Google Cloud Agent Builder. You can absolutely use Antigravity as part of your dev workflow (it's a permitted AI-assisted coding tool per the question above), but your submission still needs to be built within the Google Cloud Agent Builder ecosystem (visual Studio console OR ADK / Agent Runtime / Cloud Run). See the agent architecture question for the full requirements.

 PARTNER-SPECIFIC

Q: [GitLab Track] Can I participate in the GitLab track without GitLab Premium or GitLab Duo?

Yes. Please use a trial account to get access to the GitLab MCP server. Your use of GitLab's official MCP server will be noted in evaluation.

Q: [Arize Track] Will the Arize team provide dummy trace data for Phoenix MCP, or do we need to generate our own?

For the fastest path, set up a free Phoenix Cloud account on Arize's SaaS at <https://app.phoenix.arize.com/>. Phoenix is fully open-source, so you can also self-host if you prefer — see <https://github.com/Arize-ai/phoenix>. You'll generate your own trace data either way.

Q: [Elastic Track] My Elastic Cloud free trial (14 days) will expire before submissions close on June 11 — and before judging. What are my options?

Elastic isn't able to extend the free trial period, but here's what to do:

- **Need more time during the build:** create an additional trial account with a new email and remote-reindex your content into the new project. See [Elastic's reindex API docs](#).
- **For your submission:** include your hosted environment URL even if access will expire before/during judging.
- **Demo video is your backstop:** make sure your 3-minute demo video clearly captures everything valuable from your Elastic environment in action. Judges can rely on this when the live environment is unavailable.

Q: [MongoDB Track] Are MongoDB Atlas / the MongoDB Atlas API counted against my Google Cloud free credits? Is the MongoDB Gemini CLI extension free?

Two parts:

- **MongoDB Gemini CLI extension** — free to use. Requires a Google account (check the [Gemini CLI requirements](#)).
- **MongoDB Atlas** — if you're new to Atlas, sign up via the [Google Cloud Marketplace](#) or MongoDB's signup portal. A **free tier cluster** is available with limited storage.
- **Using Atlas with your Google Cloud credits** — subscribe to MongoDB through the Google Cloud Marketplace for unified billing. That way your Atlas usage draws down your hackathon credits cleanly instead of requiring a separate MongoDB billing relationship.

Q: [Fivetran Track] My Fivetran free trial is only 14 days and will expire before judging concludes on July 6 — what are my options?

Fivetran isn't able to extend the free trial beyond the standard 14 days. Two pieces of guidance:

- **Time your trial strategically.** Activate your trial close to the submission deadline so you can record your demo video while the trial is still active.
- **Submission is what's judged, not the live state.** Judges evaluate your submission based on what you've submitted (project URL, demo video, repo, etc.). As long as your video and other submitted assets clearly show Fivetran working end-to-end in your project, the trial expiring before July 6 won't affect your judging eligibility.

- **Demo video is your backstop.** Make sure your 3-minute demo captures Fivetran functioning in your project clearly. Even if Fivetran is no longer active in your live hosted app at judging time, you'll still be in great shape.

SUBMISSIONS & PRIZES

Q: Can I submit to multiple tracks? Can a single project win prizes in multiple tracks?

You can participate in multiple tracks — but **each submission can only enter one track**. To compete in more than one, build a **separate, unique project** for each track. A few rules to keep in mind:

- Each submission must be unique and substantially different from your other submissions (Section 7 of the rules).
- A single submission can only win **one prize maximum** (Section 8).
- If you end up winning prizes across more than one track, Google reserves the right to

allocate prizes at its sole discretion (Section 7, Multiple Submissions clause).

In short: you can absolutely build one project per track and be eligible for prizes in each — just make sure each project is genuinely distinct.

Q: Does the hosted Project URL need to be fully accessible to judges without login?

A no-login sandbox demo with preloaded sample data is acceptable, as long as judges can test the core agent workflow end-to-end. You don't need to expose production OAuth flows or private user data — stick to a clear, accessible demo that shows the agent in action. Make sure the demo video also clearly captures the agent functioning, as a backstop.

Q: Can I use an existing project, or expand on a previous idea?

You can **explore old concepts**, but the project must be **newly created from scratch** during the Contest Period (May 5 – June 11, 2026). You cannot incorporate, modify, or extend pre-existing codebases or work. A new iteration of an old idea is fine; reusing code is not.

Q: Can I use third-party APIs or open-source services in my project?

Yes, as long as you're authorized to use them under their standard terms and they don't directly compete with Google Cloud or your chosen track partner (e.g., don't use a competing database API if you're on the MongoDB track). Make sure all dependencies are properly licensed and disclosed in your repo.

Q: Will sample/training datasets be provided for the Fivetran, Arize, or Dynatrace tracks?

No — participants are expected to use public datasets or generate their own mock data. Judging evaluates autonomous agent functionality, not data science model accuracy, so **the**

scale or volume of your data isn't graded. A small, hyper-realistic dataset that demonstrates clear multi-step agent reasoning beats a massive generic one. Suggested sources:

- **Fivetran track:** public SaaS / database schemas (e-commerce, CRM mock schemas on GitHub).
- **Arize track:** open-source LLM evaluation datasets / public prompt-response logs (Hugging Face).
- **Dynatrace track:** synthetic system telemetry logs, public APM datasets, or small local server log outputs.

Still have a question? Post a new topic on the Discussions page at https://rapid-agent.devpost.com/forum_topics and we'll get back to you.

Good luck building!